

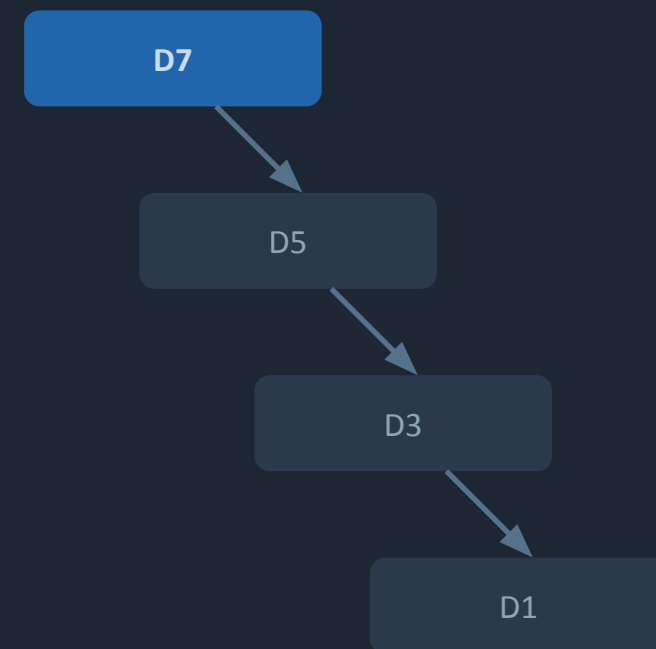
Where do they go?

Testing whether migration flows explain gentrification in London

Census origin–destination data, 2011 & 2021 · 982 London MSOAs · IMD deprivation ladder

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Mini-conference · July 2026



Why follow the movers?

1

The classic chain

Affluent residents move in; poorer residents are pushed down the hierarchy (Marcuse 1985).

2

Mechanism inferred, not observed

Most studies infer the cascade from neighbourhood attributes;
Few analyse origin–destination migration flows directly, at whole-city scale, with open data.

3

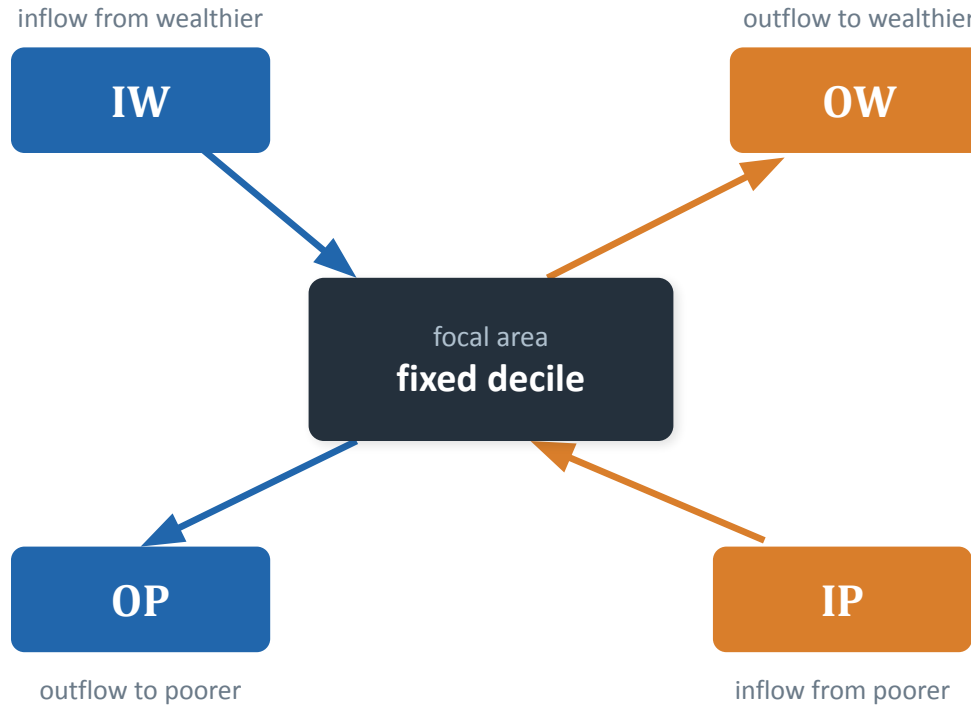
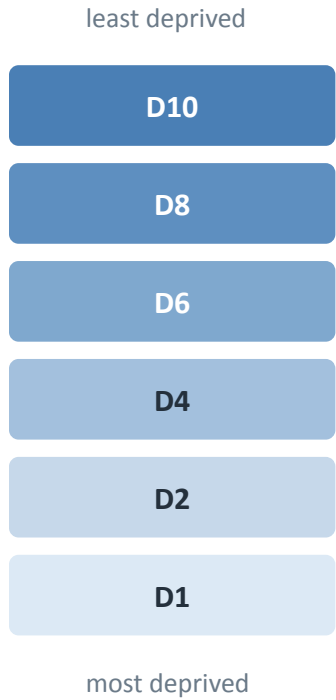
Direct evidence is inconsistent

Mover-level studies do NOT consistently support a strong downward cascade (Ding et al. 2016; Freeman et al. 2024)

Can migration flows themselves define gentrification?

IDEA *Treat the cascade as a hypothesis rather than an assumption.*

Making the cascade measurable



CASCADE
= IW + OP
wealthier in,
poorer out-and-down

COUNTER
= OW + IP
the mirror direction

IMD 2010, held fixed for both censuses

Data: all open & anonymised — 982 London MSOAs · Census OD flows 2011 & 2021 (Nomis) · IMD 2010

TAKEAWAY *We can now measure the cascade directly.*

Making the cascade testable

1 • CLASSIFY EVERY AREA

Cascade dominance

which direction carries the ladder-crossing churn
(Dennett & Stillwell 2008)

Cross-decile share

how much turnover engages the ladder at all

Cascade-led

Symmetric

Counter-led

Lateral

*Cascade-led = the candidate definition
(made operational)*

2 • THREE FRAMES

A

London flows • London ladder
CORE lens

B

London flows • national ladder
isolates re-ranking

C

+ external flows • national ladder
adds boundary effects

*~69% of London sits below national D6, so Frame A
stays the faithful lens.*

3 • THREE INDEPENDENT CHECKS

Outcome

IMD percentile change, 2010 → 2019
Did deprivation actually improve?

Attribute

Yee & Dennett (2022)
Agreed with established attribute classification?

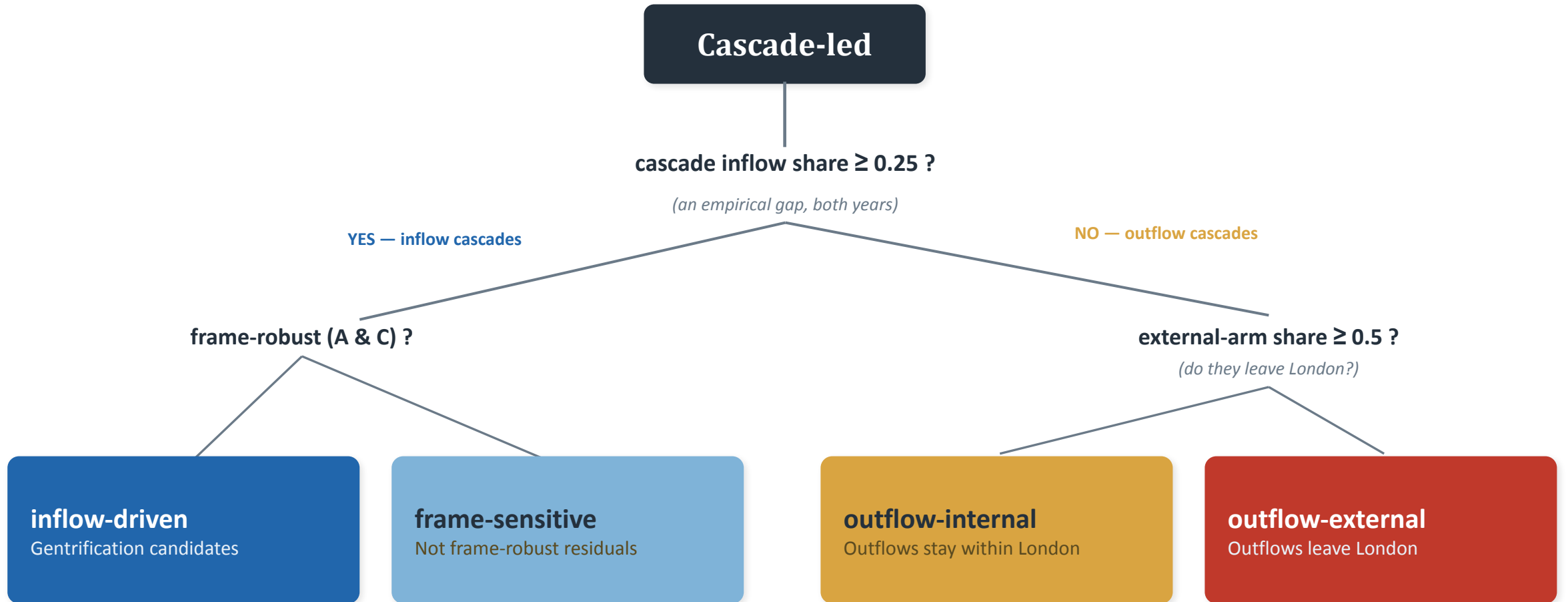
Composition

Occupational ascent
Any rise in SOC major groups 1–3?

If cascade = gentrification, all three should agree.

TAKEAWAY *Cascade-led is the testable candidate.*

Separating mechanism



TAKEAWAY Every cascade-led area lands in exactly one leaf, applied identically to 2011 and 2021.

Flow and attribute definitions only partly overlap

16

areas where both agree
Yee-GEN and cascade-led

25

attribute-only
Yee-GEN, no cascade

197

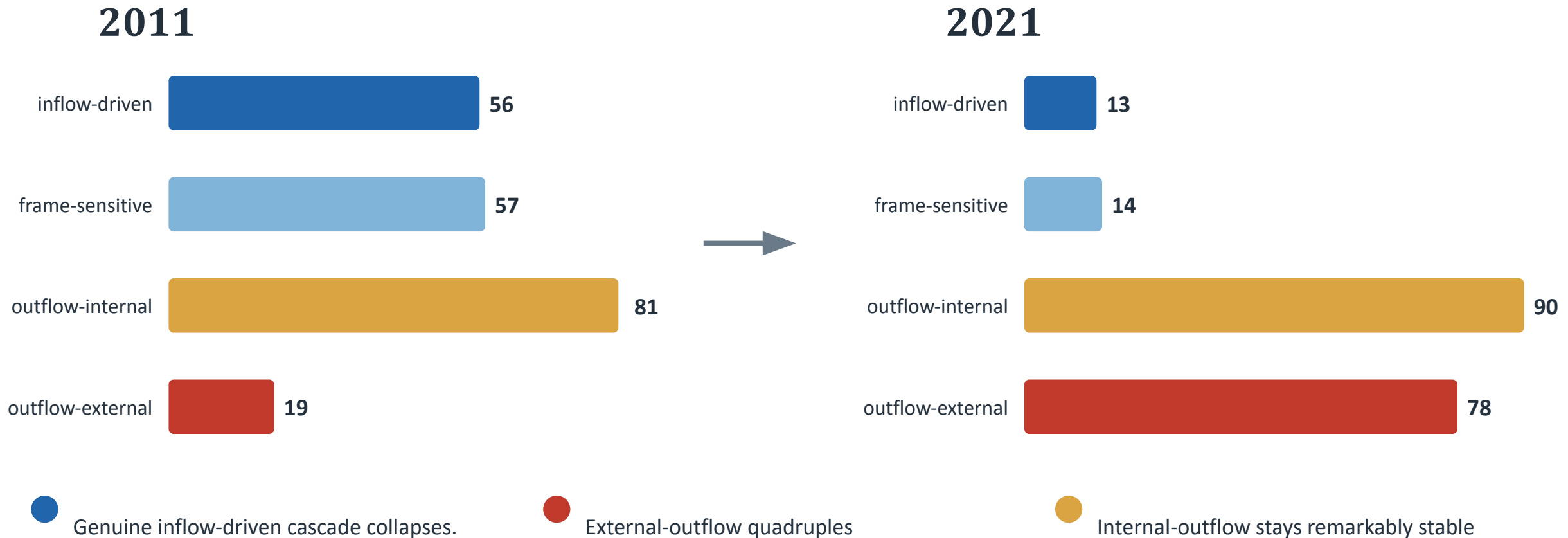
flow-only
cascade-led, no Yee-GEN

The IMD kicker — adding a cascade signal on top of Yee-GEN weakens, not strengthens, the deprivation gain.

The twist — the flow method's own deprivation signal sits in the **counter** direction; the rare agreement is 2011, inner London. Occupational ascent concurs.

TAKEAWAY *The two lenses measure different things — but is “cascade-led” one mechanism, or several wearing one label?*

Cascade-led changes dramatically over the decade



TAKEAWAY *Identical cascade statistics — produced by very different underlying processes.*

Which mechanism actually corresponds to gentrification?

Where does Yee's GEN actually live? (enrichment vs base rate, Fisher-tested, BH-corrected — numbers spoken, not shown)



outflow-internal

✓✓ **Strong enrichment**

the only cell significant on BOTH 2011 and 2021



inflow-driven

✓ **Weak enrichment**

concurrent only — does not persist



outflow-external (exodus)

✗ **GEN-depleted**

not gentrification moving out — external corroboration



counter-led

✗ **GEN-depleted**

the anti-gentrification direction, both clocks

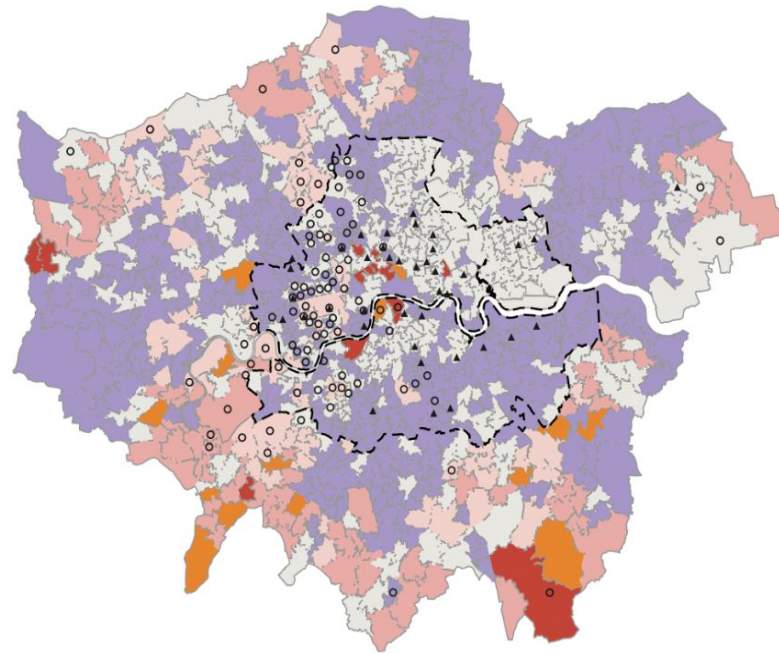
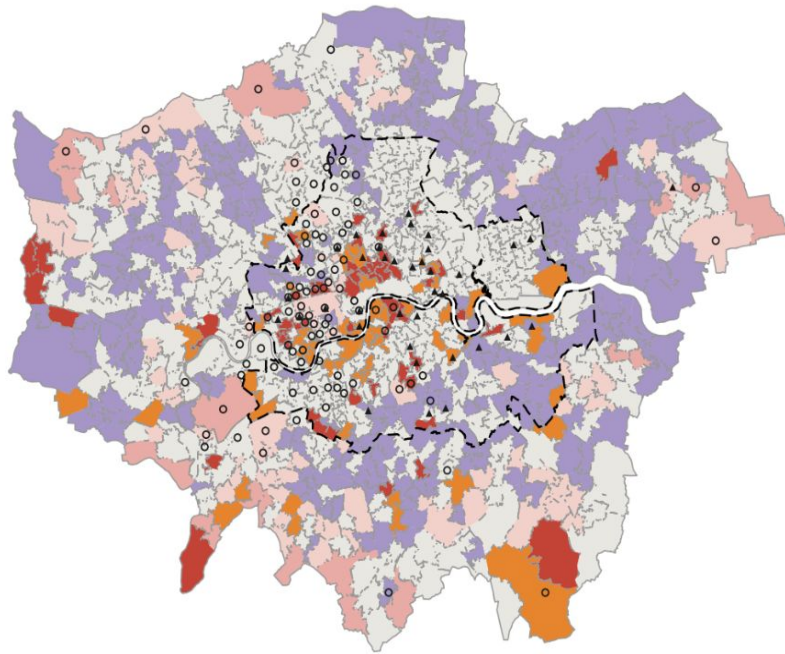
TAKEAWAY *Attribute-defined gentrification lives in the internal-OUTFLOW branch — why?*

Different gentrification subtypes occupy different flow mechanisms

Flow mechanisms vs Yee & Dennett (2022) gentrification subtypes — super-gentrification tracks the displacement arm, mainstream the arrival arm

2011 — concurrent validation
(Yee labels describe 2001-2011 change)

2021 — decade-later persistence test



Mainstream gentrification

- Inflow-driven

Super gentrification

- Internal-outflow

NOT gentrification

- External-outflow

SupGen x outflow-internal: lift 2.32 ($q = 0.0019$) · MainGen x inflow-driven: lift 2.25 ($p = 0.0654$)

SupGen x outflow-internal: lift 3.37 ($q = 1.2e-09$) · MainGen x inflow-driven: 0 of 13

■ Inflow-driven cascade
 ■ Outflow: external-majority
 ■ Counter-led
 ○ ≥ 1 SupGen LSOA (Yee, $n = 94$)
 - - Inner London boundary
■ Frame-sensitive inflow
■ Outflow: internal-majority
■ Symmetric / Lateral
 ▲ ≥ 1 MainGen LSOA (Yee, $n = 39$)

TAKEAWAY *Two lenses see the same city through different arms of the cascade.*

So, where do they go?

1 · Cascade $\neq$ Gentrification.

2 · Identical cascade values can arise from different mechanisms.

3 · “Where people go” depends on flow mechanisms, not simply origins/destinations.

Gentrification is better characterised by a persistent, inflow-led, inner-London cascade, coinciding with attribute ascent.

Gentrification is best understood as a set of migration mechanisms.

What this adds — and what it can't say

CONTRIBUTIONS

1

A framework that separates re-ranking, external migration, and genuine cascade processes.

2

A mechanism tree that separates gentrification's subtypes — mainstream in the arrival arm, super-gentrification in the displacement arm.

3

An open-data, reproducible, whole-city flow lens — public census OD + IMD across all of London.

LIMITATIONS

Ecological — area of origin is a noisy proxy for a mover's wealth — which itself explains the decoupling.

Temporal mismatch — flows 2011→2021; IMD 2010→2019; Yee labels 2001–2011 — hence the two-clock framing.

Ladder ceiling — top deciles cannot be inflow-led; the SupGen alignment is part substance, part construction.

Lockdown census — March-2021 suppression and imputation degrade the flow estimates.

TAKEAWAY *Stated plainly, so they don't come back as objections. Next: case-study chapter & spatial characterisation of the divergence.*

Thank you

Questions welcome

KEY REFERENCES

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Ding, L., Hwang, J. & Divringi, E. (2016). Gentrification and residential mobility. *Reg. Sci. Urban Econ.* 61.

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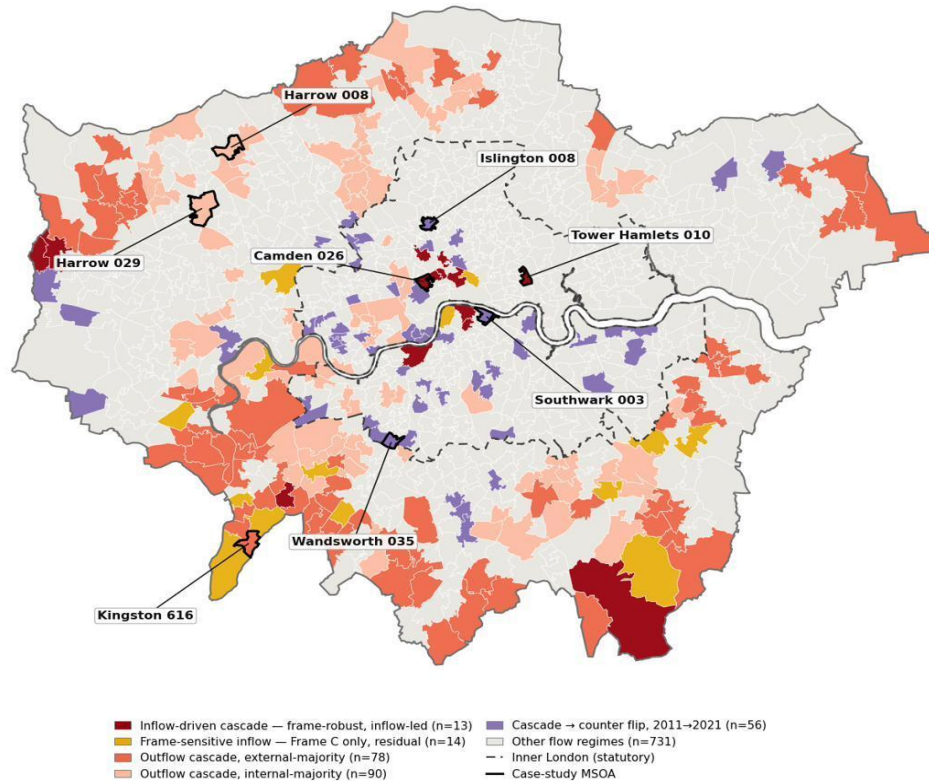
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Smith, D. (2022). Tracking gentrification in London and Manchester using 2021 Census occupational class data. *CityGeographics*.

Yee, J. & Dennett, A. (2022). Stratifying and predicting gentrification in London. *Trans. Inst. Br. Geogr.* 47(3).

Four neighbourhoods, four mechanisms

Flow mechanisms across London — EDA 9 tree, 2021 classes, with case-study exemplars



A · Genuine cascade

Camden 026 · Tower Hamlets 010
inflow-driven in both years (2 of only 8 city-wide); both arms thick, frame-robust. Yee-modal Stable — the flow lens sees what attributes miss.

B · Cascade → counter

Southwark 003 · Islington 008 · Wandsworth 035
IMD keeps improving, yet flows flip counter-led by 2021 — the decoupling made visible (Finding 1).

C · London-contained outflow

Harrow 008 · Harrow 029
outflow-internal (ext arm 0.43 / 0.41): poorer outflow stays within London — a structural feature of the national ladder, not exodus.

D · Literal exodus

Kingston 019 · Croydon 044
outflow-external: near-zero inflow, majority of out-moves leave London. One baseline member, one emergent by 2021 (Finding 2).

C and D share near-zero inflow — only the out-arm destination differs: “exodus” is measured, not relabelled.